

THE ULTIMATE

# Sea to Sky Highway Trip Planner

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Vancouver to Pemberton

Every stop, hike, restaurant, and hidden gem along the way

[bestseatosky.com](https://bestseatosky.com)

2026 Edition

# Your Sea to Sky Road Trip

The Sea to Sky Highway (Highway 99) is one of the most spectacular drives in the world. Winding 150 kilometres from Vancouver to Pemberton through coastal rainforests, alongside fjord-like Howe Sound, past thundering waterfalls, and beneath towering granite peaks.

This planner covers every worthwhile stop along the route, organized into three sections: Squamish, Whistler, and Pemberton. Use it to plan your perfect day trip, weekend getaway, or week-long adventure.

## At a Glance

|                |                                                     |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Total Distance | Vancouver to Pemberton: 150 km (2.5 hrs non-stop)   |
| Best Time      | June - September for full access; Winter for skiing |
| Fuel Up        | Fill your tank in Squamish or Whistler              |
| Start Early    | Leave Vancouver before 8am on weekends              |
| Book Ahead     | Whistler accommodation fills fast in peak season    |

# Section 1: Horseshoe Bay to Squamish

**Drive time: 45 minutes | Distance: 55 km**

Your journey begins where the highway meets the ocean. The road hugs the coastline with Howe Sound stretching out to your left — a deep, glacier-carved inlet surrounded by forested mountains.

## Stop 1: Porteau Cove Provincial Park

*25 min from Horseshoe Bay*

Waterfront park with stunning views across Howe Sound. One of BC's most popular scuba diving spots. Rocky beach and mountain backdrop make it perfect for photos. Small campground available.

## Stop 2: Britannia Mine Museum

*Just past Britannia Beach*

Fascinating look at BC's mining history. Underground train tour takes you deep into the mountain. Gold panning is a hit with kids. Budget 90 minutes.

## Stop 3: Shannon Falls Provincial Park

*10 min south of Squamish*

BC's third-highest waterfall at 335 metres. Viewing platform is a 5-minute walk from parking. Most impressive in late spring with snowmelt.

## Stop 4: Sea to Sky Gondola

*Next to Shannon Falls*

Ride 885 metres up to the Summit Lodge. Walk the Sky Pilot Suspension Bridge. Hiking trails at the top. Restaurant with incredible views. The signature Sea to Sky experience.

Explore more: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-attractions-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-attractions-squamish)

## Section 2: Squamish — The Adventure Capital

Squamish has transformed from a quiet highway town into one of BC's most exciting destinations. World-class climbing, hiking, mountain biking, and kiteboarding — plus a thriving food and craft beer scene.

### Where to Eat

The dining scene punches well above its weight. Start your morning at one of the beloved local cafes. For lunch or dinner, you'll find everything from farm-to-table bistros to wood-fired pizza. After a day of adventure, the craft breweries are the perfect reward — several taprooms offer mountain views with your pint.

Full guide: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-squamish)

Breweries: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-breweries-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-breweries-squamish)

Cafes: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-cafes-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-cafes-squamish)

### What to Do

#### Hiking

The Stawamus Chief is the iconic climb — steep granite scramble with three summits. For something easier, try the Four Lakes Trail or the Estuary Trails.

#### Rock Climbing

World-class destination with the second-largest granite monolith in the world. Routes for every ability level.

#### Mountain Biking

Consistently ranked among the top destinations in the world. Hundreds of kilometres of trails.

#### Water Sports

The Squamish Spit is one of North America's top kiteboarding spots in summer.

Full guide: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-squamish)

Things to do: [bestseatosky.com/guide/things-to-do-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/things-to-do-squamish)

### Where to Stay

From downtown hotels to riverside cabins and excellent campgrounds. Squamish is significantly more affordable than Whistler — a great base for exploring the whole corridor.

Full guide: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hotels-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hotels-squamish)

## Section 3: Squamish to Whistler

**Drive time: 45 minutes | Distance: 60 km**

The highway climbs through the Cheakamus Valley. The landscape shifts from coastal to alpine — the trees get bigger, the mountains get closer, and the rivers run glacier-blue.

### **Stop 5: Brandywine Falls Provincial Park**

*20 min north of Squamish*

One of the most photogenic waterfalls in the corridor. Brandywine Falls plunges 70 metres into a deep volcanic canyon. Viewing platform is an easy 10-minute walk. Continue to Swim Lake for a dip in summer.

### **Stop 6: Tantalus Lookout**

*Watch for the pullout sign*

Pullout on the left side of the highway. Head-on view of jagged, snow-capped peaks and the Tantalus Glacier. One of the most dramatic mountain panoramas accessible from a highway in Canada.

Waterfalls guide: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-waterfalls-squamish](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-waterfalls-squamish)

## Section 4: Whistler — World-Class Mountain Resort

Host of the 2010 Winter Olympics, North America's largest ski resort, and a year-round destination for outdoor adventure, dining, shopping, and nightlife.

### Where to Eat

The restaurant scene ranges from casual apres-ski pubs to upscale fine dining. Whether you want a massive burger after a day on the slopes or a five-course tasting menu, Whistler delivers. Book ahead for weekend dinners during peak season.

Full guide: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-whistler](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-whistler)

Cafes: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-cafes-whistler](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-cafes-whistler)

Breweries: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-breweries-whistler](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-breweries-whistler)

### What to Do

#### Winter

World-class skiing and snowboarding across Whistler and Blackcomb mountains, connected by the Peak 2 Peak Gondola. 8,000+ acres of terrain.

#### Summer

Massive bike park, alpine hiking to meadows and glacial lakes. The same mountains offer a completely different experience.

#### Year-Round

Scandinave Spa, Squamish Lil'wat Cultural Centre, Audain Art Museum, shopping, and nightlife.

Skiing: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-skiing-whistler](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-skiing-whistler)

Hikes: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-whistler](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-whistler)

Things to do: [bestseatosky.com/guide/things-to-do-whistler](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/things-to-do-whistler)

### Where to Stay

From the iconic Fairmont Chateau Whistler to cozy slope-side lodges. The Village is most convenient but priciest. Creekside is quieter with its own gondola. Budget tip: midweek rates are 30-50% less.

Full guide: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hotels-whistler](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hotels-whistler)

## Section 5: Whistler to Pemberton

**Drive time: 30 minutes | Distance: 35 km**

The final stretch climbs over the Nairn Falls corridor before dropping into the wide, flat Pemberton Valley. The landscape opens up dramatically — farmland surrounded by massive mountain peaks.

### Stop 7: Nairn Falls Provincial Park

*Just south of Pemberton*

A 1.5-kilometre trail through old-growth forest leads to Nairn Falls — a powerful cascade where the Green River forces through a narrow rock gorge. Far less crowded than Shannon Falls and equally impressive.

### Pemberton — The Hidden Gem

Pemberton's small-town charm, stunning valley setting, and growing food scene make it worth the extra 30 minutes from Whistler. The must-do is Joffre Lakes Provincial Park — three turquoise glacier-fed lakes that are among the most photographed spots in all of BC.

Restaurants: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-pemberton](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-restaurants-pemberton)

Hikes: [bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-pemberton](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/best-hikes-pemberton)

Things to do: [bestseatosky.com/guide/things-to-do-pemberton](https://bestseatosky.com/guide/things-to-do-pemberton)

# Packing Checklist

What to bring for your Sea to Sky adventure:

- Hiking boots or sturdy trail shoes
- Layers — mountain weather changes fast, even in summer
- Rain jacket (it's BC, be prepared)
- Sunscreen and sunglasses
- Water bottle (refill stations at most parks)
- Camera or phone with storage space
- Snacks for the trail
- Cash for parking meters at some trailheads
- Swimsuit (lake swimming in summer!)
- Bear spray if hiking remote trails
- Binoculars for wildlife spotting
- Reusable bags (Leave No Trace)

## Planning Tips

- Best time to go: June through September for full access. Winter for skiing.
- How long you need: A full day minimum. A long weekend lets you explore properly.
- Fuel up: Fill your tank in Squamish or Whistler. Stations get sparse north of Whistler.
- Book ahead: Whistler fills up during ski season and summer weekends.
- Start early: The highway gets busy on weekend mornings. Leave before 8am.
- Joffre Lakes: Day pass required in peak season. Book at [bcparks.ca](https://www.bcparks.ca).



## Explore the Full Directory

|                           |                                                                           |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Restaurants</b>        | <a href="https://bestseatosky.com/eat">bestseatosky.com/eat</a>           |
| <b>Hotels &amp; Stays</b> | <a href="https://bestseatosky.com/stay">bestseatosky.com/stay</a>         |
| <b>Activities</b>         | <a href="https://bestseatosky.com/play">bestseatosky.com/play</a>         |
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### Best Sea to Sky

850+ listings across Squamish, Whistler & Pemberton

[bestseatosky.com](https://bestseatosky.com)